ORAL HISTORY TRANSCRIPT

Walter Mendygral Oral History - Side B

Continuation of the oral-history interview with Walter Mendygral, including his World War II service and the Mendygral family history.

IDENTIFIER	CGDA-0001	**RUNTIME**	41:31
INTERVIEWEE	Walter Mendygral	**INTERVIEWER**	Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
PARTICIPANT	Josephine Mendygral	**RECORDING**	Side B | English

Transcript note. This transcript was generated using automated speech recognition and received a machine-assisted editorial review. Speaker names, spelling, and clearly supported wording have been corrected. Bracketed unclear passages require human review. The audio recording remains the primary source.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
00:03

No, that's okay. Only I'll be the only one listening to it.

Josephine Mendygral
00:08

Well, I've forgotten where I met him.

00:15

But what? Is it on again?

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
00:18

Yeah, that's okay. It doesn't matter. Okay, so court-martialed - what does that exactly mean?

Josephine Mendygral
00:25

Oh my god.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
00:29

What happened?

Walter Mendygral
00:30

They cut me out of flying. I was court-martialed not to fly.

00:39

So then I was in a gunnery school in Las Vegas, shooting snakes that came out of the ground. While I was there-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
00:56

Is that actually what were supposed to do? That.

Walter Mendygral
00:58

That was a gunnery school.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
00:59

Okay.

Walter Mendygral
01:05

So in the meantime, a lot of fellows were coming into that gunnery school, and I found an article. Because I was mostly in the office working, I found an article that told me how I could become a liaison pilot.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:28

Uh-huh.

Walter Mendygral
01:29

So I applied for it. I was accepted. I was surprised.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:35

I was surprised. So you could do that even though you had been court-martialed and weren't supposed to.

Walter Mendygral
01:42

Yes.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:44

So when you got court martialed and you weren't supposed to fly, like what were you.

Walter Mendygral
01:44

[Unclear]

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:49

Were you... You were just kind of doing the gunnery thing in the meantime? Like, were you trying to.

Walter Mendygral
01:53

Figure out where you were going to go next? They were sending you to school until somebody needed you someplace.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:59

Okay.

Walter Mendygral
02:02

So in the meantime, while I'm going to gunnery school, this thing shows up. They're looking for liaison pilots to train.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
02:14

Do you think if you hadn't been court-martialed and you were still where you were, learning to fly-

Walter Mendygral
02:21

The court-martial was kind of a fancy way of putting it in to scare you.

Josephine Mendygral
02:25

Uh.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
02:27

Okay.

Walter Mendygral
02:28

But actually, it had no bearing, because as soon as I applied for it, I already had some flying time, and I was a pilot before. They couldn't take away what I already had.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
02:44

Okay. So do you think you would have been sent over to Europe had you stayed where you were?

Walter Mendygral
02:45

So.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
02:51

Or is there there was oh you don't know.

Walter Mendygral
02:51

Oh, I don't know. was... Oh,.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
02:53

Okay.

Walter Mendygral
02:55

All of a sudden, a letter comes from someplace around Philadelphia. It said I should go to Georgia to take flying lessons in a [B-75 or B-25 - unclear]. That was a killer of an airplane.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
03:22

What do you mean by that?

Walter Mendygral
03:24

It was hard to fly.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
03:25

Why? What do you mean by that - it was a killer of an airplane?

Walter Mendygral
03:39

And after I applied over there, I was sent there. I had to go see a general, but the papers were already there. The guy says, 'Why are you here when you can't fly?' I said, 'They can't take my flying away.' He says, 'Well, what do you want to do?' I said, 'Well, this kind of flying, I think it's pretty safe.' And he says, 'Well, in this country it is. Overseas, would you follow the law?' I said, 'Yeah.'

04:30

So I was supposed to go to the Arab countries, like where they were fighting then, when I finished.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
04:37

Yeah.

Walter Mendygral
04:40

That was a long course. That was about four months flying.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
04:45

So wait, you told the guy - the general - that you-

Walter Mendygral
04:45

So.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
04:48

-could still fly because they couldn't take that away.

Walter Mendygral
04:51

Yeah. And he says to me, 'All right, I'll accept you.'

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
04:51

Okay. Then he said that's fine. Or okay.

Walter Mendygral
04:59

'You're a pilot. That'll be easier to train you,' and this and that and those and these. He said, 'So you don't have to go for this course.' I said I didn't care for it. I didn't know what this course consisted of, but when I saw what it was, I didn't

care for it. He said, 'You're doing the right thing. You are the type of pilot we are looking for - safety.'

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
05:30

Okay. So you just wanted to deal with safety.

05:39

So you could have gone over to where they were fighting the war then, but you did not get there.

Walter Mendygral
05:47

Well, I was scheduled to go there. But every time they scheduled us, it was getting toward the end of the war. And then when they scheduled us, we would go to the shipping area where we were supposed to ship from, in [unclear], Georgia. So they-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
06:17

Hold on one second. So, were supposed to go to the Arab countries, but every time you were supposed to go, it kept getting towards the end of the war, so it was, like, or put off.

Walter Mendygral
06:26

Yeah.

06:30

It didn't matter, because they only picked so many men, and I never fit the category. I was a little too old.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
06:44

How old were you?

Josephine Mendygral
06:51

[Unclear background speech]

Walter Mendygral
06:59

So, they sent me, uh….

Josephine Mendygral
07:03

[Unclear background speech]

Walter Mendygral
07:06

Yeah. I went there with a guy who was a sergeant. When he got there, he took off to see his girlfriend someplace in Kentucky. He took off and never came back. They brought him back as a prisoner.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
07:33

Yeah.

Walter Mendygral

07:33

The MPs caught him, and I took over the studies over there.

07:51

I was running that school there, and that was about the time the war ended.

Josephine Mendygral

07:58

[Unclear background speech]

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

07:59

When you were studying at the school in Oklahoma?

08:25

So, that's it? That's the war?

Walter Mendygral

08:27

As far as I was concerned.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

08:29

Okay. Well, I've got some more questions for you. That, that was, that was really good. Um, did you enjoy being in the Army?

Walter Mendygral

08:46

Well, I didn't enjoy it, but they had to be, so I was there. Okay. They always sent you to a different place, from one place to another, hoping to fit in. But I fit, the best part I fit was, so far, there's a place in Oklahoma.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

09:10

So, is that why you stayed there? So, once they found someplace you.

Walter Mendygral

09:13

Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

09:26

Now, when you say fit, do you mean, like, fit in, like, with the rest of the people, or what you were learning there, or what? You.

Walter Mendygral

09:35

Mean fit? Yeah. Well, I, I was a pilot to begin with, and it was just a matter of fitting a category.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

09:49

Of what kind of.

Walter Mendygral

09:50

I was a liaison pilot. I was supposed to follow instructions. I would teach people how to identify objects to bomb or shoot up.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
10:23

So, as you're flying, you tell someone else where to shoot, or bomb. Is that right?

Walter Mendygral
10:28

Yeah. Either we were supposed to carry out wounded soldiers, or different things we had to do. We were more of a humanitarian enterprise.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
10:43

Why? Why is that again? Why?

Walter Mendygral
10:46

We were more like a humanitarian enterprise. Mm-hmm.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
10:51

Why how come? What would it why why do you say that?

Walter Mendygral
10:54

Why do you say that? We were supposed to help the Army, or anybody that needed us. We were supposed to help them identify objects to bomb, all kinds of different things. Okay.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
11:20

So, when you said fit, you meant, like, what kind of pilot? That's what you meant? Like, you finally found your fit in being.

Walter Mendygral
11:30

Yeah, that is that.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
11:35

Is it... Wait, no, I'm... So, that's where you... You finally were a liaison pilot when you went to Oklahoma, right? Yeah. Okay. You weren't a liaison pilot anywhere else?

Walter Mendygral
11:47

No.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
11:48

Okay.

Walter Mendygral
11:54

Graduated to school there in Oklahoma and stayed. Of course, staying in the Army in one place too long was never an occurrence.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
12:11

It was never what?

Walter Mendygral
12:12

It never was an occurrence being too long in one place. If they needed you, you fit the category, that's where you went. Did.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
12:28

You... So, you didn't like the Army lifestyle very much either?

Josephine Mendygral
12:33

[Unclear background speech]

Walter Mendygral
12:33

No, I wasn't much of an army person.

12:42

And the treatment I got with the National Guard, that taught... That taught me that everything is for the buck.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
13:17

Emotionally, how was it... What was it like to be in the Army?

Walter Mendygral
13:24

Emotionally? Well, it was a way of life.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
13:30

So, just got used to it and... If they.

Walter Mendygral
13:34

Told you to do something, you did it.

13:40

Most of the officers didn't know what to do at the beginning.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
13:52

How was... When you first got there, was the transition pretty hard?

Walter Mendygral

13:57

What Oklahoma?

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
13:58

No. Well, mean, just got... In Hawaii. Yeah, when you first got there, period, was it... How was the transition?

Walter Mendygral
14:04

Yeah, it wasn't very good. Emotionally I didn't care for him.

14:17

Everybody was buttering themselves.

Josephine Mendygral
14:20

Oh, yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
14:31

Okay. Now, I like this story. This is going to be one of the most important things in my paper. When you went AWOL to marry Grandma - what does AWOL mean again?

Walter Mendygral
14:45

Absent without leave.

Josephine Mendygral
14:51

[Unclear background speech]

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
14:53

So you just chose to kind of take off. How long did-

Josephine Mendygral
14:57

[Unclear background speech]

Walter Mendygral
14:58

They told me to record a certain day in.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
15:03

Oklahoma. So you were in Las Vegas. What year was this - the year you got married?

Walter Mendygral
15:07

Married? I was in, uh... Las Vegas Gunnery.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

15:11

Okay.

Walter Mendygral

15:12

Okay. They picked out certain guys, and when the guys figured who they got to be, the guy that was going to take them, there was this guy... I forget his name. But anyway, he was a sergeant. I was supposed to be his assistant.

Josephine Mendygral

15:33

Because I knew what I was talking about. So,.

Walter Mendygral

15:38

He went to see his girlfriend, and he never showed up back.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

15:43

Yet. Oh, that's.

Walter Mendygral

15:44

Right. So, left me in charge. And in the meantime, when they were picking the people to go to this gunnery school, at the gunnery school, to learn how to fly, liaison, they picked a bunch of guys that were...

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

16:04

Hold on. I thought you were in Vegas. What? I thought you said you were in Vegas,.

Walter Mendygral

16:09

Right? Yeah, I was in Vegas.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

16:11

So, but I thought you were only a liaison pilot in Oklahoma.

Walter Mendygral

16:12

But I thought you were only a liaison pilot in Oklahoma. That's what they were picking. Out of this place, they were picking at this gunnery school, soldiers to go to continue flying.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

16:30

Okay. So, had been chosen, but you didn't go to Oklahoma yet.

Walter Mendygral

16:34

Well, they decided that I wasn't guilty of anything.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

16:39

Seriously. Oh, for when you left?

Walter Mendygral
16:41

Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
16:41

Yeah. Okay. So, you were in Las Vegas, and then you came back to Chicago to marry Grandma.

Walter Mendygral
16:47

Yeah, because it was the trip they gave us to go to Chicago, from Las Vegas to Salt Lake City, from Salt Lake City to Chicago, from Chicago. We were supposed to go back down to Texas.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
17:06

Okay, hold on. So, were in Vegas, and then you came here to marry Grandma,.

Walter Mendygral
17:13

Well, I went AWOL.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
17:15

AWOL, right. So you just kind of took off.

Walter Mendygral
17:18

And we had so many days to make the trip.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
17:21

Yeah.

Walter Mendygral
17:21

Yeah. I took advantage.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
17:23

Of it. Oh, so you took a longer trip than you were supposed to.

Walter Mendygral
17:26

That's why... No, I just took so many days to get there. And everybody that was with me decided how they wanted to go, as long as they stayed within the limits of the trip. So,.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
17:43

So how did you go AWOL? I don't understand, because if that's it-

Walter Mendygral
17:48

They gave me twenty-some days-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
17:51

Yeah.

Walter Mendygral
17:52

-to get to Oklahoma City, wherever it was. It wasn't Oklahoma City; it was some field in Oklahoma that they were going to use for training. So when I left, I took my route through Chicago.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
18:18

Mm-hmm.

18:22

Okay, so wait-

Walter Mendygral
18:23

Some of the guys took different routes, but they were supposed to be at this place-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
18:32

In twenty days.

Walter Mendygral
18:40

[They were selected] to learn to fly because they had been prisoners of the Japanese.

18:50

They were captured by the Japanese someplace - in the Philippines, I guess - and they were put in prison. They were Japanese prisoners.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
19:04

[Acknowledgment unclear]

Walter Mendygral
19:05

But when they picked these guys, they had the same amount of time to get to the school, because that school wasn't open yet. It was just opening, so you had until a certain day to-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
19:24

Get there. Okay. So you had to go from Las Vegas to Oklahoma in 20 days. And you had the 20 days, but the school wasn't quite open yet. So everyone could take the different routes if they wanted to. So basically, they had some extra time. they could kind of travel around if they wanted to. So you went to Chicago to get married. But then you came back late?

Walter Mendygral
19:45

No, I never came in late. I was the first one there - two days ahead of time. We had to wait for an Army officer to come and process us, and he showed up two days late. There were about ten of us. We left the gunnery school by rail and were supposed to report at a certain place on a certain date.

20:30

And I did that. Most of the guys with me had been prisoners of the Japanese. They were Americans who had been captured someplace in China or the Philippines. When they returned to America, they were sent to gunnery school until further notice. That's how they came to be there.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
21:15

I'm still confused on how you went AWOL.

Walter Mendygral
21:19

I wasn't AWOL. They just said I was AWOL.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
21:23

So you went to marry Grandma while you were traveling from Las Vegas to Oklahoma?

Walter Mendygral
21:34

Yes, I took-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
21:36

So why did they say you went AWOL?

Walter Mendygral
21:38

Well, I say I was AWOL because I wasn't following the instructions.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
21:38

Why would they do that?

21:43

Because you went a little off track?

Walter Mendygral
21:45

Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
21:46

Yeah. But they never said you went AWOL? No. Okay. Let me write this down. Hold on one second.

Josephine Mendygral
21:54

[Unclear background speech]

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
21:56

No, I think I don't know.

Walter Mendygral
21:57

It's not a screw-up story; it's true. That's the way the Army operated. As long as you never got in trouble with the Army - and I never did - when they told me to be somewhere, I was there. I could take any route I wanted, as long as I arrived. They gave me railroad tickets.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
22:37

So, okay. So you said yourself that you went AWOL. Those are your words, but not the Army's, right?

Walter Mendygral
22:47

Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
22:49

So you guys never got a honeymoon.

Josephine Mendygral
23:00

[Unclear background conversation]

23:11

Are you still coming with us tomorrow?

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
23:14

Oh yeah.

Walter Mendygral
23:15

What's the name of that place?

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
23:17

Oh, I don't know.

Walter Mendygral
23:18

What's the name of the school?

Josephine Mendygral
23:20

I forget where we are.

Walter Mendygral
23:20

Well, I'm not sure.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
23:21

I forget when. I don't know. don't don't know.

Josephine Mendygral
23:24

[Unclear place-name discussion]

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
23:32

It's not supposed to be too far, wherever it is. So when you came back to marry Grandma-

Walter Mendygral
23:36

It's on 111th Street.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
23:43

Grandma, how long did he stay here? About three days?

Josephine Mendygral
23:47

I think no, I think more than more. Huh.

Walter Mendygral
23:52

No.

23:55

Because you've got to figure out, I think around 20 days to travel. It took me time to get from where.

24:05

I was in the gunnery school to Salt Lake City. From Salt Lake City, I took a train to Chicago. From Chicago, I took a train. I.

Josephine Mendygral
24:16

[Unclear]

Walter Mendygral
24:19

Many times I did from there, but not that time. I think it took two or three days to travel.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
24:27

So, was Grandma expecting you? Like, when did you propose?

Walter Mendygral
24:32

Well, when I come to Chicago.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
24:35

One of the times to visit.

24:42

Do you remember?

Josephine Mendygral
24:42

You know, on Valentine's Day when I met him, a priest was trying to marry us. The priest was fine.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
24:52

Oh that's funny.

Josephine Mendygral
24:53

He was taking them home.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
24:55

Yeah.

Josephine Mendygral
24:55

Yeah. And then they wanted me to go home with them, but I did. I don't think I did. I don't remember.

Walter Mendygral
25:02

I already know that.

Josephine Mendygral
25:04

But the priest was marrying us that first day.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
25:07

Oh, that's funny.

Josephine Mendygral
25:08

It was [name unclear] and then-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
25:09

Yeah.

Josephine Mendygral
25:13

-his wife. That was their wedding. We went to their wedding. He went with his family, and I went with my cousin Junior, or somebody. We went to the same wedding.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
25:26

So how did he ask you out? What happened?

Walter Mendygral
25:27

Mike [unclear].

Josephine Mendygral
25:31

Mike?

Walter Mendygral
25:31

Mike? Yeah, Mike was.

Josephine Mendygral
25:33

[Unclear]

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
25:36

Oh no.

Josephine Mendygral
25:38

He got us to dance.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
25:42

Together? Oh, yeah? Someone kind of set you two up? And then what?

Josephine Mendygral
25:50

Did we take the priest home together?

Walter Mendygral
25:53

Uh no, I don't think so.

25:58

Sure, don't remember.

Josephine Mendygral
25:59

I don't remember how it followed up from there.

Walter Mendygral
25:59

Hard response.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

26:00

Yeah.

Walter Mendygral
26:07

Sixty years ago. you want?

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
26:11

So do you remember how you asked her out?

Josephine Mendygral
26:20

[Unclear background speech]

Walter Mendygral
26:23

No, I don't think so.

Josephine Mendygral
26:27

See, Carrie, you are taking too long.

26:32

Okay. But I know that's where we went in that on Valentine's Day. That.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
26:36

Guy's awake. Well, look, you remember. I want to know.

Walter Mendygral
26:40

Oh, forget it. The mind is.

Josephine Mendygral
26:45

Oh, Jesus.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
26:48

So.

Josephine Mendygral
26:49

Okay.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
26:53

No.

Josephine Mendygral
26:54

Carrie has a few more questions, too.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
26:57

Did you think you were going to go to Europe to fight, or no?

Walter Mendygral
27:02

I don't know.

Josephine Mendygral
27:05

His brothers were all overseas.

Walter Mendygral
27:08

I was the only one-

Josephine Mendygral
27:08

He had four brothers, and he was the fifth one.

Walter Mendygral
27:12

I was the first one in the Army because I I joined the Army before we were at war.

Josephine Mendygral
27:14

Joey, Stanley, Earl, and Roy.

27:19

War. He was the first one in, and just.

Walter Mendygral
27:22

First one out.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
27:24

Yeah.

Josephine Mendygral
27:24

Yeah. Four years.

Walter Mendygral
27:27

Four years.

Josephine Mendygral
27:28

It was just when the war was ending.

Walter Mendygral
27:35

Well, I had an application.

Josephine Mendygral
27:37

By that time, I think I had Carol. Didn't I.

Walter Mendygral
27:42

Have Carol? No, you didn't have Carol,.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
27:44

Too. You were in South Carolina or North Carolina?

Walter Mendygral
27:47

Carroll was in nineteen forty-three.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
27:50

Forty four.

Josephine Mendygral
27:51

Forty three down married. Yeah,.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
28:01

So how did you get to see your family? How did you get to see Grandma when you were over there? just went, like just once a month, you get to go and leave, and that's when you saw her? That's it?

Josephine Mendygral
28:13

That's it. Whenever he got to.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
28:15

So just like once a month, that kind of stuff.

Josephine Mendygral
28:16

Not even that.

Walter Mendygral
28:18

Whenever whenever you could swing something, you could you found out you had some days off, you asked them if you put.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
28:18

Okay.

Walter Mendygral
28:26

If you could go. All right, so they'd give you three days, five days, and then after that you had to be back. I was never late, I was never early.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
28:39

So?

Walter Mendygral
28:41

See, I worked in the office most of the time. I used to run the office. Most of the officers who were supposed to be there didn't know what was going on. I was the only one who happened to know, and I could ship you anywhere in the country.

Josephine Mendygral
29:06

[Unclear background speech]

Walter Mendygral
29:09

Same way.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
29:16

So how did you plan a wedding when you were in the Army?

Walter Mendygral
29:20

I just came home, and my mother decided we should-

Josephine Mendygral
29:20

[Unclear]

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
29:24

We should do that. And so you didn't even.

Josephine Mendygral
29:26

See, I was going to go with Auntie Wanda because her husband was [unclear] at the time.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
29:33

Yeah.

Josephine Mendygral
29:37

She was going to get married, and so was I. His mother wrote us a letter. He was her first son, and she wanted to make him a little wedding. We should come home.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
29:49

Oh, so wait - but how did you-

29:59

And you came home, and then you got married. Oh, wait - were you the baby?

Josephine Mendygral
30:06

Well, who is the oldest?

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
30:07

Oh, he is the oldest?

Walter Mendygral
30:08

Thank you.

Josephine Mendygral
30:09

Yeah, he's the oldest one.

30:14

[Unclear background speech]

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
30:16

So she wanted you to get married here, so that's what happened?

Josephine Mendygral
30:19

Yeah, so she wanted to make a little wedding, so.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
30:24

Huh.

Josephine Mendygral
30:25

That's what I think. But, like I said, I didn't want a-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
30:27

But you wanted to get married, right? He asked you and all, right?

Josephine Mendygral
30:35

-wedding, because I got money from my mother's accident when she was killed by a car.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
30:42

I thought she was walking.

Josephine Mendygral
30:44

No.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
30:44

Oh, no - yeah, she was walking across the street when-

Josephine Mendygral
30:48

A car hit her.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
30:49

Right. I thought it was a bus.

Josephine Mendygral
30:52

She got off the bus, coming home from downtown.

Walter Mendygral
30:57

[Unclear]

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
30:57

Yeah.

Josephine Mendygral
30:57

I'm sorry.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
30:59

Yeah, mom kind of messed up, I think. Or maybe I messed.

Josephine Mendygral
31:02

And the one man who did see her get hit said her body flew all the way over. He was an organist at [church name unclear].

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
31:18

Okay.

Josephine Mendygral
31:20

Years later, I met him at [place unclear], and he recognized me from when I was a child.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
31:25

Really,.

Josephine Mendygral
31:31

Talking to him brought back the whole accident and everything. The next day, I went to Holy Cross Hospital, where I think she was.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
31:35

Yeah.

Josephine Mendygral
31:42

By the time they let me go to see her, we were supposed to have a party at-

31:48

-our house. I don't know, some graduation party or some kind of party. The first time she bought me a skirt - a sort of blue color - I shortened it myself, and I was so happy I could show her that I did it myself. She never got to see it. She died before the party. Her back was all broken.

32:26

It was like a sack. By the time they let me go up to see her-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
32:32

Mm-hmm.

Josephine Mendygral
32:40

I did want to see her before she died. Somehow they didn't get me in there. Frank got in.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
32:47

So you saw it.

Josephine Mendygral
32:49

[Unclear] I mean, we were just kids.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
32:55

Yeah. But he she probably at least said something too.

Josephine Mendygral
32:55

You know.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
32:58

Your brother.

Josephine Mendygral
32:59

I just.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
32:59

For you.

Josephine Mendygral
33:00

No, I think she was on that.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
33:01

Yeah.

Josephine Mendygral
33:02

[Unclear]

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
33:05

Did she suffer, or was it just kind of - she was alive, but-

Josephine Mendygral
33:11

That's it. She didn't really feel anything. I think by morning she was-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
33:17

-gone. So she did not suffer very much?

Josephine Mendygral
33:20

[Unclear]

33:26

But that man, when I saw him years later, recognized me from when I was a child.

33:35

He was an organist at [church name unclear].

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
33:39

He played the organ at-do you remember?

Josephine Mendygral
33:43

[Unclear]

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
33:49

She was coming home from downtown, from work.

33:58

So you didn't want a wedding - like a church wedding?

Josephine Mendygral

34:09

The trip to California was about seventeen hundred dollars. You know how far that would go now.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

34:09

Oh, okay. That's right, because you were saying you had money from your mother.

Josephine Mendygral

34:19

Yeah. So I made the trip to California with Wanda, too.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

34:19

Yeah.

Josephine Mendygral

34:25

[Unclear discussion of Wanda's wedding and returning home]

Walter Mendygral

34:42

When I was in Texas.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

34:43

How long did you two date before you got married?

Josephine Mendygral

34:47

It was over a year. It was February, and we got married in July.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

34:56

So less than a year?

Walter Mendygral

34:56

It was February of one year and July of the next year.

Josephine Mendygral

34:58

February.

34:59

February. And then I could not even get my-

Walter Mendygral

35:01

[Unclear]

Josephine Mendygral
35:04

When we were going downtown to get the papers-

Walter Mendygral
35:04

She was home enough.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
35:08

Because you lied about your age, did you? So the truth came out.

Josephine Mendygral
35:16

I had to take insurance papers and other documents to prove my age.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
35:25

So you started dating when you were sixteen?

Josephine Mendygral
35:28

Sixteen or seventeen, somewhere around there.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
35:31

Seventeen? And how old was grandpa? How old were you grandpa?

35:39

It was good. So wait, okay. So you guys dated for Yeah.

Josephine Mendygral
35:42

There were about seven years between us.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
35:45

Yeah. So, when you got married, you were 18 and.

Josephine Mendygral
35:48

Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
35:50

Oh no - twenty-six.

Josephine Mendygral
35:51

He was twenty-six. I had just turned eighteen - March, April, May, June, July. Yes, I had turned eighteen by then.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
36:04

So you dated for about a year and a half?

Josephine Mendygral
36:07

Yeah, it must have been about that time because but he wasn't.

Walter Mendygral
36:09

I wasn't home most of the time.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
36:12

Yeah.

Josephine Mendygral
36:12

We were mostly together by-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
36:14

-letters. So how did you know you wanted to get married if you did not get to see each other?

Josephine Mendygral
36:18

There were letters every day.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
36:21

Oh.

Josephine Mendygral
36:23

Every day there were letters. I don't know what happened to them. I had his Army letters and-

36:31

-cards. Finally, my kids found-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
36:34

-some of them. And you got rid of them?

Josephine Mendygral
36:36

Grandma found some of them. They didn't believe it was him. There was his handwriting.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
36:47

You don't have any more, do you?

Josephine Mendygral
36:49

I do not know. I might have some.

Walter Mendygral
36:52

[Unclear]

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
36:54

Nothing too, yeah, revealing.

Josephine Mendygral
36:59

They found them in my drawer someplace. I had kept them all those years. I even had a handkerchief that his brother Stanley sent me from Hawaii.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
37:19

Yeah.

Josephine Mendygral
37:19

It was like a crepe-

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
37:22

Uh-huh.

Josephine Mendygral
37:23

I still have it with my handkerchiefs.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
37:26

Really?

Josephine Mendygral
37:26

After all these years, yes. One of them also sent me a little vial of perfume from overseas. It cost five dollars at the time. That was Stanley - or Joey or Stanley, one of them.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
38:01

For a wedding gift?

Josephine Mendygral
38:02

A wedding gift? No, just as a gift.

Walter Mendygral
38:05

Emo was on the West Coast.

Josephine Mendygral
38:08

Yeah, so, that was so crazy, yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
38:15

No, I still can. Let us take a look.

Josephine Mendygral
38:17

[Unclear]

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
38:21

Let me see.

Josephine Mendygral
38:22

It might not be there, unless I got rid of it. But I know that perfume dried out after all the years. I never opened it because I treasured it.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
38:36

Oh sorry.

38:43

Yeah, should I get it?

Walter Mendygral
38:44

[Unclear]

Josephine Mendygral
38:47

Oh yeah, right there. Yeah, yeah.

39:01

[Unclear background conversation]

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
39:19

So what was it like to come home? Was it, like, relief?

Josephine Mendygral
39:23

[Unclear background conversation]

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
39:24

Or yeah.

Walter Mendygral
39:24

I don't remember.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
39:25

Don't remember.

Walter Mendygral
39:27

I know I applied for, to let me out. A couple of days later, I took care of most of the bankers there, as I worked in the orderly room. And, uh, I was sent to camp, uh, over here on,.

Josephine Mendygral
39:48

[Unclear background conversation]

Walter Mendygral
39:54

It was an Army base, yes.

Josephine Mendygral
39:55

Uh-huh.

Walter Mendygral
39:57

[Unclear]

Josephine Mendygral
40:04

They're hard to start, but once they start-

40:11

-they come back. I just cut mine down, and they come back every year.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
40:16

All right.

Josephine Mendygral
40:18

Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
40:19

That's all my questions. That was a great interview, Grandpa. Thank you.

Josephine Mendygral
40:23

[Unclear background speech]

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
40:24

It went really well.

Walter Mendygral
40:25

And uh we we were good soldiers. It was just uh the Army was so disorganized that uh the reason we won the war.

Josephine Mendygral
40:30

[Unclear background speech]

Walter Mendygral
40:36

Is they were more disorganized than we were.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
40:39

Who? Oh, the other countries?

Josephine Mendygral
40:46

No, mine are old already. Mine have been here for years because they come back year after year. At the end of summer, before winter, I cut them down.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
41:06

So how are you feeling?

Josephine Mendygral
41:08

Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
41:08

You know?

Josephine Mendygral
41:10

Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
41:10

You seem kind of crabby.

Josephine Mendygral
41:12

Sort of.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
41:17

Well, you didn't want to do the interview.

Josephine Mendygral
41:19

[Unclear]

Walter Mendygral
41:21

That's what I remember.

End of Side B. Repository: Carrie Gabaree Digital Archive.